

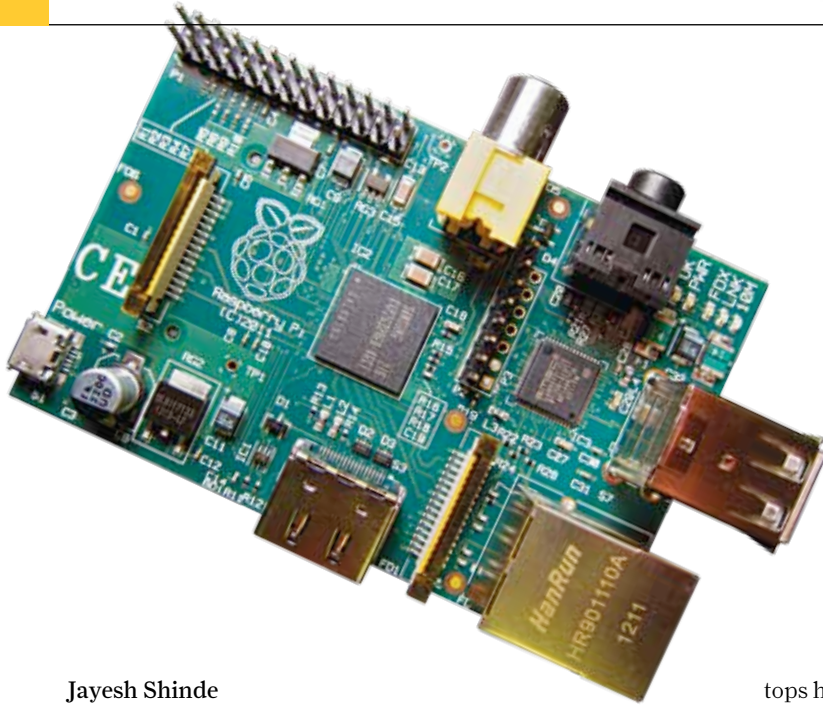
Sharing files in OS X

When emailing someone a file, attaching is one option. There are other ways to do it too. Find out here: <http://dgit.in/NphKvL>



Chinese Dragon Flash Drive

Silicon Power unveils the Dragon theme Touch 836 USB flash drive in India. It's design is based on bronze colour with Chinese Dragon <http://dgit.in/Q3qddY>



Thumb PCs: A silent revolution?

Jayesh Shinde

jayesh.shinde@thinkdigit.com

Late last year, news of a credit card sized mini computer developed in the UK spread like a wildfire. Boasting all the elements of a fully functional traditional desktop PC – CPU, RAM, graphics, storage slot, ethernet port, HDMI out, USB port and 3.5 mm jack – the whole device along with its circuit board weighed only 45gm and cost \$35! Talk about a revolutionary PC that could fit into your shirt pocket and go easy on the wallet. Not only had the prototype device generated enough buzz and excitement, it also managed to attract enough potential customers for this tantalizing “breakthrough” in modern computing to be out of stock within no time. The Raspberry Pi has been referred to by many glowing adjectives since then, and its unheralded launch has spurred others on the path of designing and manufacturing truly tiny, thumb-sized PCs. But is the trend a flash in the pan or an inevitable force of future computing?

Steady revival

People have been making tiny PCs against the dominant form factor of their respective generation for ages. But what the Raspberry Pi has done is to bring back the spotlight firmly back on tiny PCs at a time in personal technology where PCs have shrunk into tablets, lap-

tops have shrunk into ultrabooks, and mobile phones

have morphed into performance beasts sporting quad-core processors. The semiconductor industry is all about shrinking silicon dies and thinner fabrication processes, but while chips are getting smaller their performance is soaring. For the first time in the history of computing successful, mass market handheld products like smartphones and tablets sport faster processors and better tech than most table-top desktop or laptop PCs. It's no surprise that the cult of Thumb PCs should get revived now, aiming to strike the proverbial iron while it's still hot, hoping to make a permanent dent across the personal computing landscape.

As technology consumption becomes mass market, companies are waking up to the fact that most consumers of technology expect their gadgets to be fancy but at the same time less complicated. Also, most people who use the latest

tech gadgets and who've experienced the digital age and forms of personal technology fairly late in their life, use gadgets and PCs for extremely basic work. A traditional PC with the latest quad-core processor coupled with multiple GBs of RAM is wasted and redundant on folks interested in merely surfing the Web and working on documents. For such consumers, the prospect of a cost-effective Thumb PC becomes a lot more attractive. Feeding the demand is a steady number of manufacturers who've identified a niche market.

PC re-imagined

Apart from the \$35 Raspberry Pi, the \$74 Mele A1000 is one such cost-effective Thumb PC launched earlier this year. Albeit bigger than the Pi, the Mele can dual-boot Android 2.3 and Ubuntu, boasting an underlying hardware comprising a 1.2GHz Cortex A8 ARM chip with a MALI400MP OpenGL ES 2.0 GPU and 512MB of RAM. Connectivity ports include a VGA port, audio-video in, eSATA port, two USB 2.0 ports, SD card slot and an ethernet jack. The thing also has 2GB of onboard flash storage and 802.11 b/g/n Wi-Fi support. It's potentially marketed as a media device.

The APC from VIA is another tiny PC with a lot of promise. Measuring slightly larger than an iPhone, the APC is a \$49 Android PC that packs quite a punch. The device has an 800MHz ARM



The Mele A1000 with its I/O ports